

"Hockey is an art which calls for intelligence, keen eyes, powerful wrists, physical fitness and speed."

SORCERER'S SCORE

A lowly officer of the Brahmin Regiment, the maestro showed India and the world that artistry has nothing to do with social status and everything to do with inborn talent

Dhyan Chand

Hockey player 1905-1979

■ By K. Arumugam

India's glorious hockey journey—a medal in the Olympics from 1928 to 1980 except once in 1976, including eight gold—would not have started but for a friendship between two British colonels who were part of Gallipoli tragedy during the First World War. Their friendly gesture in 1926, an Indian Army hockey team's first tour of New Zealand—also a maiden foreign visit by any Indian hockey team—dug a bonanza. Even as the hosts were amazed at the classic hockey being showcased in front of their eyes, the visitors also realised that they were indeed a world apart.

One man who mesmerised the Kiwis and whose extraordinary skills spontaneously led the Indians think of taking part in the Olympics, was Dhyan Chand. In that epoch making motley group of 16 stick artists, the 18-year-old "other rank" soldier from the Brahmin Regiment stood out. Not

because he scored the most goals, but for the grace and ease with which he could do them. Each of the goals he scored was a hockey lesson in itself.

At the next three Olympics between 1928 and 1936, in which India strode like a colossus, Dhyan Chand lived up to his reputation and the faith reposed by the Indian Hockey Federation—it never called him for selection trials. The defending champion England, after entering the 1928 Olympics, made a hasty retreat after seeing Dhyan Chand at the Folkstone Festival Hockey en route Amsterdam.

It was a rare historical occurrence that a colonial country could keep out one as mighty as the British Empire from a particular sport for three Olympics. It is ironical that the same British, 80 years later, would defeat India in the Chile qualifier and thus ensure their forerunner's first exit from Olympic hockey in 80 years.

Jesse Owen's exploits at the 1936

